

US: WESTERN STATES

FROM THE ICY LANDSCAPE OF ALASKA, through the deserts of Nevada and Arizona, to the semitropical islands of Hawaii, the western states cover a dramatic range of scenery. Along the West Coast, large cities such as Seattle, Portland, and San Francisco ship lumber, fish, and fruit all over the world. The West is also home to Hollywood, capital of the multimillion dollar movie industry, and Silicon Valley, a stretch of northern California that lies at the heart of the high-tech computer business. Sun Valley, in Idaho, ranks as one of the country's leading ski and summer resorts.



THE NORTHERN FORESTS

Great forests of pine, cedar, and fir trees thrive in the wet climate near the coasts of Oregon and Washington. These states are the country's major suppliers of lumber and wood pulp. The trees are cut into logs and transported by road to the coast. Environmental groups are now trying to protect the trees, many of which are more than 200 years old.

EARTHQUAKE COUNTRY

People in California have to live with the constant threat of earthquakes. The area lies on the boundary, or fault line, between two plates of the Earth's crust. When these plates push and slide against each other, it causes earthquakes, which can destroy roads and homes. It is difficult to predict an earthquake, so most people keep a survival kit in case they are trapped or left without supplies. Some of the items included in such a kit are displayed here.

FAULT LINES

The San Andreas Fault runs for 750 miles (1,207 km) across California, passing through the cities of San Francisco and Los Angeles. There are also hundreds of other smaller faults that constantly cause minor tremors.

- Major fault
- Minor faults



Heavy-duty flashlight

Packet of pure drinking water



Lightweight bag of emergency items, including first-aid supplies (not shown)

Bar of dried food with vitamins

Mini rolls of toilet paper

Towelette

Disposable toothbrush with toothpaste

Light sticks work for 12 hours and do not need batteries.

Emergency blanket designed to reflect body heat



SOUTH OF THE BORDER

The majority of immigrants living in the western states come from nearby Mexico. They are called Hispanics because their ancestors came from Spain and they speak Spanish. Many still follow the religion and festivals of Mexico. Hispanics also arrive from Cuba, Puerto Rico, and El Salvador.

FIELDS OF PLENTY

Fertile soil, plenty of sunshine, and water, diverted from rivers that flow from the Sierra Nevada Mountains, make California the leading agricultural state. The land is used to grow more than 40 percent of the fresh fruit and vegetables eaten in the US, such as peaches, oranges, and strawberries, as well as artichokes and brussels sprouts. Mexicans often cross into the country illegally to find work on the fruit farms. The Napa Valley, north of San Francisco, is an important grape-growing and wine-producing area.



CAR CULTURE

When Henry Ford introduced the first cheap car in 1910, it promised freedom on the open road. Today, there are more cars on the road in the US than in any other country. Networks of six-lane highways weave across cities such as Los Angeles, shown above. Fumes from the cars contribute to city smog problems.

CARS PER 100 PEOPLE		
US	 77	
France	 47	
Denmark	 35	
Brazil	 14	
India	 0.7	